

The Professional Standards and Competencies for Teachers

Unit 2 asked how a teacher should act. Unit 3 asked what effective teaching is. This unit asks the question that follows both: **can any of that be written down in a form that a whole system can use?**

That is what a professional standard attempts. It is a documented statement of what a competent member of the profession knows, values and can do, written so that training, hiring, appraisal and public accountability can all point at the same thing.

The attempt is worth taking seriously and worth being sceptical about at the same time. A standard makes quality visible and comparable, which is the only way a system larger than one school can improve. A standard also flattens judgement into indicators, and what cannot be written into an indicator tends to stop counting. This unit teaches you to use standards and to see their limits, because you will spend your career being measured by them.

Unit learning outcomes

By the end of this unit you should be able to:

- Define a **professional standard**, distinguish it from a code of conduct and from a curriculum, and explain what question each answers.
- Describe global and national perspectives on teacher standards and explain how standards are used to pursue teacher quality and accountability.

- Describe the structure of Pakistan's **National Professional Standards for Teachers**, including how each standard is internally organised and how domains relate to indicators.
- Use a standard to evaluate your own practice, and assemble defensible evidence against a single indicator.
- Explain how standards connect to **teacher licensing, certification** and appraisal, and analyse what changes when one instrument is used for both development and a promotion decision.

Prerequisite knowledge

Units 1 to 3. Unit 1 supplies professionalism, accreditation and professional bodies. Unit 2 supplies codes of conduct, which standards are most often confused with, and the difference between the two is the first thing this unit establishes. Unit 3 supplies the components of effectiveness, which a standard is an attempt to write down in usable form.

In this unit

1. **Topic 4.1 - What professional standards are for** - the concept, global and national perspectives, and the accountability argument.
2. **Topic 4.2 - Pakistan's National Professional Standards for Teachers** - the structure of the standards, the domains they cover, and how an indicator evidences a domain.
3. **Topic 4.3 - Using a standard on yourself** - self-evaluation against an indicator, and what counts as evidence.
4. **Topic 4.4 - Licensing, certification and appraisal** - where standards meet a career, and what happens when an instrument is used for a purpose it was not designed for.

How to use this unit

Work through in order. Topic 4.2 assumes the purposes established in 4.1, and Topic 4.3 cannot be done without 4.2.

Topic 4.3 is the one to do slowly. Self-evaluation against a standard is a skill you will use every year of your career, and most teachers never learn it properly, which is why appraisal so often feels like something done to them rather than something they participate in.

A note on the primary document. Pakistan's National Professional Standards for Teachers is referenced throughout and is not reproduced here. Obtain a copy and read it alongside Topic 4.2; this unit teaches you how it is built and how to use it, not what every line of it says.

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